

For a start up clothing brand, managing data efficiently is crucial for operations: including inventory management, financial records and marketing materials. This report evaluates cloud storage and hard drives, focussing on affordability, accessibility, reliability and finally ensuring the solution maintains the brand's ethos of sustainability.

Cloud storage is a cost effective and scalable solution which provides accessibility from any web enabled device. The main convenience with using cloud services is that backups are automatic, and it all occurs in the background whilst you are still working, ensuring that all data is maintained – as long as an internet connection is always present.

Examples include MS OneDrive, google drive, Dropbox.

Key benefits:

- Automatic backups and syncing
- Secure with encryption and access controls
- Carbon neutral data centres,

The best overall rated provider is Microsoft OneDrive. It has great functionality, reliability and it seamlessly integrates with Windows to allow automatic backups and file syncing as well as having compatibility with macOS. Furthermore, Microsoft as a corporation has operated carbon neutral since 2012 and aims to be carbon negative by 2030. It is important to stay integral with all operations in the brand which strives for sustainability.

However, this requires an ongoing cost and internet access is required for access to all the data as not locally stored. Larger the amounts of data will result in longer sync times.

Another option is a physical hard drive that is able to store all digital content. For the business needs, keep long term backups for all data is important and can be done routinely, it is ideal to keep these on an external HDD and once backed up keep it stored away until the next backup of data is due – this minimises any physical damage that could potentially occur and corrupt data.

Key benefits:

- Very affordable compared to other data storage devices and come as a one-off cost for the business
- Have very large base storage capacity, 2TB HDDs can be found for approximately £50
- Readily available in the market with software to help prevent corruption

However these backups will have to be carried out manually and routinely to ensure data redundancy. This can be a hassle for some as files will need to be manually saved from the computer to the harddrive and if it is done in a routinely manner , e.g once every two weeks, the new data being created within those two weeks could potentially not have a backup if the device becomes faulty in that time frame. Misplacing or physically damaging the device can also be another issue, especially if all data is being stored locally on that one device.

To conclude using a cloud service provider such as MS OneDrive will always backup data as long as an internet connection is present – which for most cases an internet connection is available in

almost every workspace. By paying £5.99 a month or £59.99 annually you are able to get 1TB worth of storage which is readily accessible and will keep the business going for a while as so far the current data only adds up to about 20GB. Moreover there is a semi hybrid approach as the computer/laptop on which data is being accessed on can be used as local offline storage also incase internet is not available, the data is still stored on the computer itself. Having the peace of mind that all files on the device are also backed up to the cloud is reassuring as no extra work needs to be done e.g manually backing up files, therefore making it a convenient option and saves time. The most important aspect of cloud is ensuring that you remember your passwords and make sure payment methods are up to date to minimise any data loss and issues that can occur. Finally choosing a cloud solution such as Microsoft resonates with the business and it's main goal of sustainability, therefore maintaining this standard from everything that we do is crucial.